

## **Argumentative Essay**

Argument is the process of organizing and stating objectively and dispassionately the facts and reasons surrounding a particular stand or point of view. In many cases, the argumentative essay attempts to influence and persuade the reader/listener to the author's opinions on a particular issue and even to effect a change in the behavior of others. For an argument to be effective, it must be relatively objective, well organized and logical. Similar principles apply in informal argument as in the different forms of daily arguments between classmates, brothers, sisters or market people. They each require that you list your reasons why or why not. Marshalling out your reasons ahead of time helps clarify your thinking, lends force and conviction to what you have to say as well as provide unity and coherence to your thought.

### **Reasons for Argument**

1. One may have a need to justify one's opinions and ideas on a particular issue or topic
2. An individual may hope to effect certain changes in a situation that one feels very strongly about. Eg electing a particular candidate, exposing injustice in a system, changing certain rules in an institution etc.
3. Most of the positive changes we see around us are as a result of someone's argument for such changes to be made.

### **Strategies for Effective Argument**

1. Effective argument must be grounded on facts, verifiable and accurate statistics as arguments are weighed by reasons and not by verbosity.
2. Effective argument should be presented in a well organized form (introduction with a thesis, paragraphs that develop topic sentences of the thesis and a conclusion that summarizes the argument and restates the thesis).
3. An effective argument must be presented objectively without passion or vehemence.
4. An argument must be based on sound logic i.e. it must avoid any emotive language, personal attacks, over simplification and generalizations. Its conclusion must be valid and true.
5. An effective argument must anticipate the possible points of the opposition in order to conquer them by overwhelming them with greater facts and figures.

### **How to Organize an Argumentative Essay**

1. Arrange your reasons in either a chronological or a logical order (according to relative importance, usually with the strongest point at the end for climatic effect).
2. Your introductory paragraph should include background information on the topic, a definition of any important term. It must also include a thesis statement, stating clearly what you intend to argue, followed by a summary of the major points you are going to advance in the order in which they will be treated.
3. In the body of the essay, each major point should be developed in one or a number of paragraphs to the extent

4. The conclusion should contain a summary of your position as well as final rounding off argument. At this point, the thesis statement should be restated in new terms.

#### **Suggested Topics for Argumentative Essay**

1. Young men are the most reckless drivers
2. The Nigeria oil boom is not blessing
3. All men are equal
4. Teachers are more essential in a community than doctors
5. Students should take active part in politics.

#### **Debate/Argumentative Essay**

A debate is an interactive and positive presentation in which two or more present their argument or persuade others to accept their point of view. It shows skill and ability in argument.

#### **Criteria for Debate**

1. Timing: the debate must be made within the specified time frame allocated. Thus the need for a time keeper
2. Presentation: the manner adopted in communicating one's ideas/views, there should be:
  - Content: sufficient information relevant to the topic
  - Organization: give a definite statement of facts supported by, experience, history or literature neatly presented on paragraphs. Let each paragraph end with a conclusion drawn from the fact. As usual, the normal debate greeting should be observed accordingly. While the introductory paragraph should be interesting and captivating enough to arrest the attention of the reader/audience.
  - Human elements used as examples
  - Expressing your argument should be as clear as possible. Figures of speech could be of great advantage if properly used.
3. Accuracy of points: your points must be generally acceptable with facts to support your views.
4. Elocution: oral delivery which involves adequate voice control, correct pronunciation. Your voice should be clear without fear.
5. Comportment: confidence to deliver with body movement without tension.
6. Appearance: your outlook, neatness and proper dressing

#### **Guidelines for Debate**

1. The Greetings eg. Mr Chairman, Panel of Judges, Moderator, Accurate time keeper, Fellow students, Distinguished guests, Ladies and Gentlemen.

2. State your vocatives
3. Define content
4. Make sure you are convinced about the side you support if not, you will run out of points.
5. Do not draw conclusion from one example
6. Oppose or counter your opponents points
7. Use polite language
8. Use rhetorical questions
9. As u end your points, say thank you
10. Strongly urge your audience to tow your line of argument.